CHALLENGE 05 · EIGHT WEEKS

Run 10 km – training plan for beginners and advanced runners

Two eight-week plans: as a beginner you double your distance from 5 to 10 km, as an advanced runner you work on your 10 km time. With a weekly plan to tick off, clear pace guidance and tips to avoid overload.

From 5 to 10 km – or faster

Eight weeks, two levels: get to the finish or run a new personal best.

8 weeks · 2 levels

How a training week is structured

3–4 runs a week · 25–75 minutes · 80% easy

Easy runs · the foundation	Most of your kilometres are run at a conversational pace. They build endurance and spare your tendons and joints.
One quality session per week	Faster sections, intervals or race-pace running make you quicker. Always with a 10–15 min warm-up and a 10 min cool-down.
The long run · once a week	It grows week by week and makes the distance familiar. Pace: easy, and slower than you think is fine.
Rest days and strength	At least one rest day after hard sessions. Two short strength sessions a week help prevent overload.

80 / 20 as a rule of thumb:
About 80% of your running time is easy and at most 20% fast or hard. Running every session fast often makes you tired rather than faster.

Your training plan

Both plans last eight weeks, with a recovery week in week 4. Repeat a week if it feels too hard – and skip a session if something hurts.

Beginner: your first 10 km

3 runs a week · Goal: finish 10 km

Week	Training	Done
Week 1 Long run: 35 min	**2× 25 min easy · long run 35 min** Start calmly: every run at a conversational pace.	☐
Week 2 Long run: 40 min	**2× 25 min easy · long run 40 min** The long run grows by five minutes.	☐
Week 3 Long run: 45 min	**2× 30 min easy · long run 45 min** Short walking breaks are fine if you need them.	☐
Week 4 Long run: 40 min	**2× 25 min easy · long run 40 min** Recovery week: a little less, so your body can adapt.	☐
Week 5 Long run: 50 min	**30 min easy with 4× 1 min brisk · 30 min easy · long run 50 min** Your first brisk sections – jog easily for 2 min after each.	☐
Week 6 Long run: 55 min	**30 min easy with 6× 1 min brisk · 30 min easy · long run 55 min** The brisk minutes now feel more familiar.	☐
Week 7 Long run: 60 min	**2× 35 min easy · long run 60 min** The longest run of the plan – often already close to 10 km.	☐
Week 8 Goal: 10 km	**2× 25 min easy – then your 10 km** Two short, easy runs and, at the end of the week, your 10 km at a comfortable pace.	☐

Advanced: a faster 10 km

4 runs a week · Goal: new personal best

Every week: one quality session, one long run and easy runs. Warm-up and cool-down are not included in the figures.

Week	Training	Done
Week 1 Long run: 60 min	**6× 400 m brisk, 90 s jog recovery** Plus 2 easy runs of 40 min. Brisk here means roughly your 5 km pace.	☐
Week 2 Long run: 65 min	**3× 8 min at threshold, 2 min jog recovery** Plus 2 easy runs of 40 min.	☐
Week 3 Long run: 70 min	**5× 800 m at 10 km pace, 2 min jog recovery** Plus 2 easy runs of 45 min.	☐
Week 4 Long run: 55 min	**4× 400 m relaxed but brisk, full recovery** Recovery week: just 1 easy run of 40 min on top.	☐
Week 5 Long run: 75 min	**3× 10 min at threshold, 2 min jog recovery** Plus 2 easy runs of 45 min.	☐
Week 6 Long run: 75 min	**6× 800 m at 10 km pace, 2 min jog recovery** Plus 2 easy runs of 45 min. Run the last 10 min of the long run a little faster.	☐
Week 7 Long run: 70 min	**2× 15 min at threshold, 3 min jog recovery** Plus 2 easy runs of 40 min.	☐
Week 8 Goal: 10 km	**4× 400 m relaxed but brisk – then your 10 km race** Taper: two short, easy runs of 30 min. At the weekend, 10 km as a race or time trial.	☐

What the terms in the plan mean

You do not need a heart-rate watch – your own sense of effort is perfectly enough to start with.

01

Easy

You can talk in full sentences. This is the pace for most runs and for the long run.

02

Brisk

Noticeably faster; you can only speak in short sentences. For short sections of one to five minutes.

03

Threshold

Comfortably hard: you could hold this pace for about an hour but can only say a few words.

04

Race pace

The pace you are aiming for on race day – whether 5 km, 10 km or a half marathon. In training you only run it in sections.

Training with heart rate?
If you use a heart-rate watch: easy runs are usually in zone 2, threshold sections in zone 4. You can estimate your zones with the heart-rate zone calculator.

Heart Rate Zone Calculator

What matters most

01
Strength still matters
The leg exercises from the 5 km challenge fit here too: twice a week, about 15 minutes.

02
Energy for longer runs
Before runs of more than an hour, a carbohydrate-rich meal a few hours beforehand helps – for example oats or rice.

03
Rest is part of training
Adaptation happens during recovery. Sleep, rest days and recovery weeks are a fixed part of the plan.

Safety first
If you have been inactive for a long time, have a medical condition (for example of the heart or circulation) or take regular medication, get medical advice before you start. Stop immediately if you experience chest pain, unusual shortness of breath, dizziness or palpitations. Pain that gets worse while running or is still there the next morning is a reason to take a break – if it persists, have it checked. This challenge is not medical advice.

My notes